ALICE IN WONDERLAND by Lewis Carroll (A2–A2+)

INTRODUCTION

Ss read an extract from *Alice in Wonderland* by Lewis Carroll in which Alice gets very big and floods the room with her tears. Ss talk about dreams and find out about classic children's literature.

Supplementary Materials

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION Ex 3: internet access

CLIL CONNECTION: internet access

WARM UP

Point to the images in the artwork (the flamingo, the locked chest, the playing cards, the rabbits, the top hat, the cupcake and the pocket watch) and, in English or L1, ask them to look at their books for 30–60 seconds to memorise the objects. Then, with books closed, ask Ss to write a list of the objects they remember. With books open, they count how many they remembered and report back. Then Ss make up a story in their heads to link all the objects, e.g. a flamingo trying to open a locked chest with a key because there are some playing cards inside. Give them time to prepare their story and then, books closed, ask them to write a list of the objects from memory again. They should, in theory, remember them all easily. Tell them this memory trick is extremely powerful and useful. It could be fun to repeat the test at the end of the class or even the next day, to prove how well the information is retained.

Culture notes

Lewis Carroll

Lewis Carroll was born in 1832. His real name was Charles Lutwidge Dodgson. He taught Mathematics at Oxford University and wrote funny and satirical poetry and short stories. In 1856, he published his first piece of work, a poem, under the name of 'Lewis Carroll'. That same year, he also met the new Dean of Christ Church and his family, who became close friends of his. He spent a lot of time with the mother and the children, Ina, Alice and Edith. They used to go out on the river for picnics and on one such expedition in 1862, Dodgson told them a story. Alice Liddell begged him to write it down. The story became *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* and was immediately very successful. In 1871, Dodgson published *Through the Looking-Glass and What Alice Found There*. He died suddenly of pneumonia in 1898.

Alice in Wonderland

Alice is a little girl who is sitting under a tree with her sister one sunny day. After she follows a white rabbit down a rabbit hole, her adventures start. She changes size many times, meets some animals who talk, a rather rude caterpillar, and a smiling cat that can vanish when it wants to. As Alice continues to explore this strange world, she meets a duchess with a baby that changes into a pig and she takes part in a very strange tea party. Finally she meets the King and Queen of Hearts. The Queen is a strange woman, who always wants to cut off the heads of the animals and people around her. Then the Knave of Hearts has to stand trial for stealing some tarts. When Alice is told to leave the trial room because she is getting too big, she refuses. She begins to fight the playing cards, but suddenly she wakes up. It was all a dream after all.

PREPARATION

THINKING ROUTINE

1

see

Focus Ss on the picture of the **Pearson English Reader**. Ask *What can you see in the picture?* (A girl in a blue dress with a white apron, protecting herself with her arm as playing cards fly around her head. Birds and small animals seem to be panicking at her feet.)

think, wonder

Divide Ss into pairs and allow time for them to read and discuss the questions. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. Briefly, check answers as a class. Ask *How are things in dreams different from in real life?* (They don't make sense and don't always have a clear cause or result. Time passes differently, very fast. You can do things in dreams that are impossible.)

ANSWERS:

think

3 Ss' own answers

4 Ss' own answers. Possible answers are that it's not a very relaxing picture as she seems agitated so that feeling could be what the Ss pick up on. Maybe they also feel curious about what is happening to her and what the book is about.

wonder

5 Ss' own answers

6 Ss' own answers. They may or may not believe dreams have meanings but can say why they think that.

READING PREVIEW

Focus Ss on the title and ask *Imagine you are suddenly three metres tall. What can and can't you do?* Elicit ideas but there's no need to confirm any as it's just to get Ss thinking.

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READING EXTRACT LL1.01

Tell Ss they are going to read an extract from *Alice in Wonderland* near the beginning of Alice's adventures. Allow time for them to read in silence, or play the recording while they read. If you're going to play the recording, focus on the glossary words in the box first, so Ss will understand them when they listen and read. Check pronunciation of 'tear' (*teer*, not *tare* which is the verb as in 'to tear paper').

When they have finished, ask *Which parts of the story are like things that happen in dreams?* (Alice growing taller, her tears make water everywhere, the white rabbit can talk and is wearing clothes.)

COMPREHENSION

2 **Focus Ss on Question 1. Elicit whether the answer is true or false or if the answer is not given in the text they have read. If they volunteer that the sentence is true or false, ask them to find the place in the text where it says so. They should not be able to find anything if the answer is not given in the text. Explain that they must decide if the rest of the questions are true, false or the information is not given.**

Allow time for them to work individually and then compare answers with a partner. Get feedback as a class, making sure they can justify their answers.

ANSWERS:

1 NG **2** T **3** F **4** F **5** NG **6** F

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

3 **Explain that the events are dream-like because the whole story turns out to be a dream Alice is having. Ask *Do you have the same dreams again?* See if Ss volunteer any common dreams, such as the ones in the questions. Don't press the issue as dreams might be very personal to some people.**

Say that some people think certain common dreams have a meaning. Focus on the three dreams and set Ss the task of finding out some possible meanings. They can use the internet, either in class or at home to do individual research.

ANSWERS:

There are many interpretations of common dreams, most of them are not very scientific or even based on good psychology, so Ss will probably find wildly varying answers.

SPEAKING

4 **Ss compare their findings on the meanings in small groups as they have probably found different explanations. Encourage them to offer their own interpretations of the three dreams too. In feedback, elicit Ss' ideas as a class and see how many interpretations there are and which one Ss think is best or most likely.**

CLIL CONNECTION

Literature

5A **Ask *What were your favourite books as a child?* Ss can call out answers or discuss in small groups and come up with a list. Next, explain that *Alice in Wonderland* was one of the first books written just for children, which may seem strange to us now that children's books are such a big part of the book market.**

Focus on the list of books and the questions and see which ones Ss know. Then allow time for them to research the books online, or at a library or bookshop to fill in the gaps in their knowledge. In feedback, ellicit Ss' answers as a class.

ANSWERS:

Peter Pan, JM Barrie published in 1911 as *Peter and Wendy*. It's about a boy who never grows up and can fly. He lives on Never Never Island and makes friends with Wendy and her brothers and brings them to the island.

The Princess and the Goblin, George MacDonald, 1872. Princess Irene rescues miner's son Curdie from some goblins, with the help of her grandmother. The goblins then plan to kidnap her but she is saved by Curdie.

The Wind in the Willows, Kenneth Grahame, 1908. It's about four animal friends and their adventures including Toad stealing a car and going to prison.

B **Ss can discuss the last question about books today in their groups. In feedback, elicit Ss' ideas as a class discussion.**

ANSWERS:

Ss' own opinions/research depending on if they go by sales/film success/influence on culture, etc. Could be modern books like *Harry Potter* or books by David Walliams, or older classics like Roald Dahl. Or, they could argue for classics from the era of *Alice in Wonderland* that have stood the test of time.

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Homework ideas

- Ss write their own story using the illustrations in the background artwork of the two pages in the Students' Book. They should aim to include as many of the objects as they can.
- Ss write a made up scene where Alice is very small.
- Ss keep a dream diary for a week and interpret their own dreams.

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